In

the first decades of the 20th century, affordable bicycles transformed thousands of Indian lives—allowing them an unparalleled mobility. While it has never quite lost its popularity in rural and semi-urban areas, the urban masses have since reposed their faith in mass transport systems, with an aspirational eye out for their first car. But the humble bicycle still had an ace up its chain, as Arjit Soni realised.

Arjit had always wanted a car, and bought one soon after he started practising as a chartered accountant in South Mumbai. But the grinding realities of Indian roads detracted from the pleasure of driving—why, it took 30 minutes to enter the parking lot of his favourite mall, and 45 minutes to exit! "As a student, I used the local train and had bought two cycles that I would use for last-mile connectivity. In college, I had a bright idea—to launch a facility where people could rent cycles—but it was shot down. Now, I was convinced about it," says Arjit. In 2014, he started MYBYK, India's first public bicycle-sharing and rental service. The idea: to obviate the anxiety caused by traffic snarls. It all started from Ahmedabad, and now the mobile app-based service operates in eight cities—including Mumbai, Nagpur, Kochi, Jamnagar, Udaipur, Indore and Valsad—and over 10 campuses. With a fleet of more than 9,000 bicycles and over 50,000 monthly customers, it makes a monthly recurring revenue of Rs 75 lakh. MYBYK integrates with public transport systems like the metro and bus networks—Ahmedabad Bus Rapid Transit System and the Kochi Metro, for example—to provide first- and last-mile connectivity. "Our core philosophy was to make public transport more accessible and convenient by solving the first- and last-mile challenge," Arjit tells INDIA TODAY. The venture was bootstrapped—a friend of his father's invested Rs 1.25 crore initially—for the first seven years; only in 2021 did it get a $1 million (Rs 8.65 crore) investment from Avon Cycles and other investors.

> **"OUR CORE PHILOSOPHY WAS TO MAKE PUBLIC TRANSPORT MORE ACCESSIBLE AND CONVENIENT BY SOLVING THE FIRST- AND LAST-MILE CHALLENGE"**
>
> **ARJIT SONI**

FACT SHEET

Name of company
MYBYK

What they do
App-based public bike sharing/ renting

Founded in: 2014

Annual turnover
Rs 9 crore

Yet Arjit found that MYBYK didn't draw funding in the way that such a green venture could have. Moreover, despite its high impact, profitability remained low because the business model was dependent on public infrastructure, and the culture of using bicycles had yet to gather high momentum despite a compelling need. A shift in focus was needed, and an obvious idea suggested itself. "Over the years, we realised that achieving our vision requires strong support in the form of policy and infrastructure—particularly cycling-friendly roads, shade and safety. Since those elements have been slow to materialise, we've chosen to strategically prioritise areas where we can drive impact and scale immediately," reflects Arjit. The company has shifted its primary focus to MYBYK Campus (for intra-campus mobility) and MYBYK Cargo, which caters to India's 1.3 million last-mile delivery riders (Swiggy, Zomato et al). This segment, he says, is growing at a 12-18 per cent compound annual growth rate (CAGR).

For the latter, Arjit had a purpose-built electric delivery bike created from scratch. The first 200 e-bikes proved to be a success; by March 2026, the company will introduce around 1,500-2,000 new e-bikes. Arjit expects his monthly recurring revenue (MRR) to double in 2026. "With the growth of MYBYK Cargo, we are accelerating toward profitability," he says.

A champion of sustainable urban mobility, Arjit recalls a 10-minute meeting with Narendra Modi in early 2014, and how the then chief minister of Gujarat gave him his first breakthrough with the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation. "I was told to present my idea in two minutes; I concluded in 90 seconds. He (Modi) was convinced about the idea and coined the term 'bicycle feeder service' for MYBYK, as an aid to the BRTS that was being rolled out," he says. That was a long time ago. Arjit now waits for urban infrastructure to catch up with an idea that arrived many monsoons back. ■